



and handed its inaugural honour to Trump during the World Cup draw in Washington without any transparent nomination or selection process. Infantino has also appeared at the launch of Trump's so-called Board of Peace.

For all the politics surrounding it, however, the tournament will ultimately be judged by the football it produces.

While soccer has traditionally struggled to fully conquer America, this World Cup might be different. Messi's arrival at Inter Miami in 2023 has done more for football's cultural legitimacy in the United States than decades of marketing campaigns.

At 39, this will almost certainly be his final World Cup. Four years ago in Qatar, he completed football's greatest redemption arc, lifting the trophy that had eluded him. Now, after three seasons in Major League

Soccer, he will play in a continent he knows intimately.

That familiarity may matter. Teams will criss-cross multiple time zones and endure travel demands unlike any previous World Cup, with distances between Vancouver, Mexico City, Miami and New York resembling continental tours more than traditional tournament movement. Messi is no longer a visiting superstar but part of the North American sporting ecosystem,

familiar with the heat, travel and media frenzy that define sport in that part of the world.

Argentina, too, retains much of the core that conquered Qatar. Seventeen members of that squad remain involved, preserving the experience that carried the Albiceleste to glory.

If Messi represents the enduring power of the old order, Europe arrives with the players most likely to inherit the future.

Spain may be the tournament's most fascinating side, with Yamal and Pedri at its heart, the faces of a generation shaped by Barcelona's La Masia and a philosophy built around movement, positional interchange and relentless pressing.

The side has evolved beyond the sterile possession football that eventually became a caricature of its own success. This Spain attacks with greater urgency, seeks overloads in wide areas and embraces risk in transition.

If Spain represents football's future, France remains its most complete present.

Led by Mbappe, now the face of Real Madrid's latest galactico project, France possesses perhaps the deepest pool of elite talent in international football. Alongside the control of Aurelien Tchouameni and the creativity of Dembele, Les Bleus are comfortable without the ball and devastating with it. They do not need to dominate possession to dominate matches.

Beyond the favourites, however, the biggest transformation is structural.

The expanded format has altered the character of the World Cup. Asia now has eight direct qualification spots and Africa nine. Nations such

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